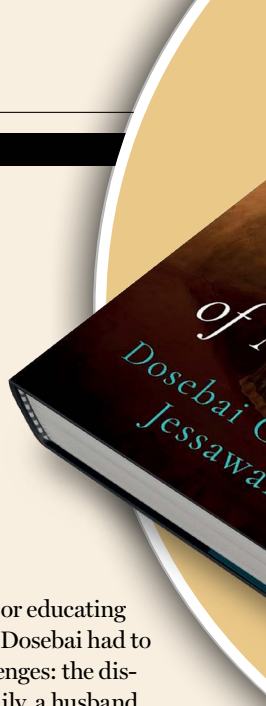
Memoirs of a Parsi Daughter

BOOKS



THE INSPIRING STORY OF DOSEBAI COWASJEE JESSAWALLA, WHO BECAME ONE OF THE FIRST INDIAN WOMEN TO GET AN ENGLISH EDUCATION

In 1842, Meheribai, a widow, enrolled her daughter in Mrs Ward's Seminary in Bombay. The decision—coming as it did when "there was a general desire to keep the fair sex in ignorance"—invited fear and loathing. Parsi newspapers carried disapproving articles; sethias threatened ex-communication; and Meheribai's own family railed against the "world-wide publicity".

Unmoved by "the wrath of the entire male portion of the whole native community", the mother refused to back down. So it was that little Dosebai ventured beyond the conservative world of Mumbai's Parsi community and became one of the first girls in India to get an English education. Soon, the same sethias were seeking discreet ways to educate their own daughters.

Meheribai's rebellion played a part in furthering women's education in India. It also shaped the life that Dosebai recounts in her autobiography, *The Story of My Life*, first published in 1911 and again by Speaking Tiger this year. It's a fascinating book that reveals how much has changed in Bombay and in the Parsi community in just 150 years. It provides a window into another age: when Bhandoop was a spot for pleasure trips and houses in Tardeo came with sprawling gardens; when driving with your husband in an open carriage or visiting Bandstand with friends was scandalous; when a slight indisposition in the morning could mean death by evening; when independent thought was as unwelcome as diphtheria.

As a child, Dosebai watched her mother fight innumerable battles to live life on her own terms, be it buying a house at Malabar Hill or educating her daughter. As a wife, Dosebai had to deal with her own challenges: the disapproval of her new family, a husband who made unwise business decisions, and 11 childbirths, of which only three children lived to adulthood.

Often, the book feels like a gossip session with friends—as when Dosebai describes a white satin saree that she embroiders in 42 colours for a family wedding. "My sisters in law, who had ordered for the occasion costly Chinese sarees, were totally eclipsed," she reports. There are also times when it reads like a travelogue, saved from tedium by the fact that Dosebai's sarees, ornaments and lively spirit open doors everywhere (including the Vatican, where she manages to get an impromptu audience with Pope Leo XIII).

Read the book for the first time,

ON WHITE MAN'S LAND

Sonora Jha weaves a potent story about US academia and the realities of race, privilege and politics

This book brought home to me a fact I have long suspected to be true, but which became very clear while I was reading it: America terrifies me. Since the beginning of this year, there have been 130 mass shootings there in 87 days; just a few days ago, there was a big one in Nashville. Life is cheap in America: you can get it for the price of a 9 mm pistol and a box of rounds from Walmart.

But don't get me wrong. This book is titled *The Laughter*, and for sure the first third of it is hilarious. The wit is like Coetzee on acid; it's like Nabokov had a sex change. However, the final third is guaranteed to wipe the smile off your face. It reminds you of how, up until World War II, Americans were largely figures of fun in literature, with their brash manners and their wilful ignorance of the world. It was only as the Cold War unfolded and Bretton Woods strangled us with foreign debt that we began to realise the sinister background to their culture. They stole a country and never said sorry.

The othering that white culture applies to everyone it doesn't approve of (including white people) is funny only when it isn't backed up by violence. Sometimes we think the violence is only intellectual, as Ruhaba Khan, the protagonist, seems to believe. Ruhaba is a poignantly visualised character, one that I recognise in my students and colleagues. She is at war with those who wish to control her, but her weapons are a headscarf and a few pages of jaunty polemic. Also, she has a weak spot: her nephew Adil Alam.

THE LAUGHTER
by Sonora Jha
HAMISH HAMILTON
₹599; 320 pages

